

DP20 – Community Ownership

The Conditions for Ownership That Can Be Exercised

1. Purpose of This Draft

This draft articulates Desirable Property 20 (DP20) as the condition under which communities meaningfully own the digital environments, surplus, and governance artifacts they co-create, not as marketing language about “community,” but as enforceable rights and responsibilities: stake, voice, upside, and continuity that persist across tools and seasons.

DP20 completes a loop with DP18 (feedback and reputation), DP19 (presence and engagement), and DP12 (community governance of AI): participation must be able to mature into ownership, otherwise “community” remains a rented audience for platforms.

DP20 connects to DP4 (data commons and collective data rights), DP6 (fair distribution of commercial surplus), DP9 (incentives that return value to contributors), DP3 (adaptive governance at scale), DP17 (financial sustainability), and DP1–DP2 (accountability and agency for collective actors).

If DP20 is weak, predictable failures follow: extractive growth on volunteer labor, token claims without decision rights, capture of governance by insiders, inability to fork when values diverge, and surplus flowing outward while risks stay local.

DP20 does not mandate a single cooperative legal form or chain. It defines minimum legitimacy conditions for what “ownership” may claim in the meta-layer.

2. Problem Statement

In today’s web, “community” is often a label applied to users whose labor, attention, and data build value they cannot capture, audit, or exit with. Governance surfaces are optional; economic upside is asymmetric; and forking social reality is impractical.

In practice, this produces recurring failures:

- moderators and maintainers burn out while platform valuation rises
- creators depend on distribution they do not control
- tokens grant speculation liquidity without durable rights
- data generated collectively is sold without collective consent (DP4)
- communities cannot carry norms, memory, or economic terms across apps (DP7)

These failures are structural: ownership is confused with usage; participation is confused with consent to extraction.

DP20 reframes ownership as operational: rights you can see, exercise, and defend, including pathways to fork, exit, and recapture surplus when legitimacy breaks.

3. Threats and Failure Modes

3.1 Ownership theater

Marketing claims “community-owned” while decisions and keys remain centralized.

Example: A DAO where a multisig admin can override any vote without published criteria.

Why this matters: DP20 requires honest mapping between claims and controls.

3.2 Token liquidity without duties or rights

Tokens trade while governance is inactive or non-binding.

Example: Voter apathy plus whale dominance makes governance a periodic headline, not a constraint on operators.

Why this matters: Ownership instruments must bind to decisions and surplus, or be renamed.

3.3 Commons maintenance without reciprocity

Value is extracted from a space while moderation, safety, and infrastructure remain underfunded.

Example: A viral forum hosts commerce ads but does not fund anti-abuse capacity.

Why this matters: Connects DP6 reciprocity and DP17 sustainability.

3.4 Capture by concentrated stakeholders

Early contributors or large holders lock rules that favor continuation of privilege.

Example: Fee switches require supermajorities that insiders can block indefinitely.

Why this matters: DP3 adaptive governance and DP12 dialectic must resist ossified capture.

3.5 Forklessness

When values diverge, participants cannot exit with continuity of identity, memory, or economic position.

Example: A community schism loses all history because export is blocked and namespaces are not portable (DP5, DP7).

Why this matters: Forking is a safety valve for legitimacy.

3.6 Collective data sale without governance

Aggregated or derived data monetizes communities without authorization pathways.

Why this matters: DP4 sovereignty requires collective decision surfaces, not only individual toggles.

3.7 Illegible membership and shadow elites

Informal power structures make decisions without published accountability.

Example: Moderators coordinate bans off-platform without records or appeals.

Why this matters: DP1 contestability and DP12 governance memory must extend to collective actors.

3.8 Philanthropic dependency

Communities rely on unsustainable grants with no path to owned revenue or shared surplus.

Example: A civic space runs on a yearly sponsor who can pull funding overnight.

Why this matters: DP17 sustainability and DP6 commerce reciprocity must appear in ownership design.

3.9 Legal hostility to collective action

Cooperative forms face banking, tax, and liability friction.

Why this matters: DP20 acknowledges law as a design constraint while still demanding honest digital rights bundles.

4. Core Principle

Community ownership in the meta-layer means participants and communities hold defensible rights to govern, benefit from, and responsibly steward the environments and surplus they co-create, including credible paths to fork, exit, and recapture value, with transparency, accountability, and continuity of memory.

Ownership is not a vibe. It is power with responsibility, visible to members and bounded by human-rights baselines and law.

Example: A community charter defines decision rights, surplus split, audit rights, and fork procedures; tools entering the zone must acknowledge the charter's machine-readable profile.

What this feels like: You are not the community in a slogan. You are a member with levers.

Without this: Participation is harvested; dignity is not.

5. Primary Mechanisms and Structural Conditions

5.1 Ownership Layer: Execution, Proof, and Exit

Community ownership requires more than charters and intent. It requires the ability to express, verify, exercise, and, when necessary, exit ownership as part of an operational system.

In many systems, “ownership” fails because it is not bound to decision rights, not provable in practice, or not portable across tools. Rights exist on paper while control remains elsewhere.

DP20 therefore requires a shared ownership layer composed of primitives that make ownership executable rather than symbolic.

5.1.1 Ownership objects

Ownership must be represented as structured, machine-readable objects that bind rights to actors and contexts.

An ownership object includes:

- scope: what environment, assets, or processes are owned
- rights: governance, economic, and data rights
- duties: stewardship and maintenance obligations
- transfer conditions: how ownership can change hands

This binds ownership directly to governance (DP3, DP12).

5.1.2 Ownership receipts

All ownership-relevant actions produce verifiable records.

An ownership receipt includes:

- who holds or exercised a right
- what action was taken (vote, allocation, fork, transfer)
- when it occurred
- what assets or policies were affected

These receipts make ownership auditable and connect to DP15 (provenance).

5.1.3 Surplus and flow proofs

Economic flows must be traceable to ownership claims.

Members must be able to see:

- how value enters the system
- how it is allocated

- how it maps to rights and contributions

Without flow proofs, ownership cannot capture upside in a defensible way (DP6, DP17).

5.1.4 Fork and exit primitives

Ownership must include executable pathways to exit or fork with continuity.

This includes:

- export of data and governance artifacts (DP4, DP7)
- migration of identifiers where honest (DP5)
- continuity of membership and contribution records

Forking is not a failure. It is a safety valve for legitimacy.

5.1.5 Membership and credential objects

Membership and contribution must be represented as portable, verifiable artifacts.

This enables:

- recognition across tools
- resistance to platform lock-in
- continuity of identity and stake

5.1.6 Ownership–governance binding

Ownership must map to decision rights in a visible way.

Participants must be able to see:

- who can decide what
- how ownership affects voting or delegation
- where overrides or special powers exist

Governance that cannot be owned is advisory. Ownership that cannot govern is symbolic.

5.1.7 Ownership memory

Ownership history must persist over time.

This includes:

- prior allocations and changes
- disputes and resolutions
- forks and mergers

Without memory, ownership becomes contestable without evidence.

These primitives do not replace the mechanisms below. They make them enforceable, portable, and auditable across contexts.

5.2 Charter and rights bundle

A written and machine-readable articulation of membership, decision rights, economic rights, data rights, fork rights, and sunset conditions.

This MUST include:

- explicit mapping between roles and powers
- conditions under which rights can change
- linkage to governance execution (DP3, DP12)

Verification:

- participants can inspect current and prior versions
- tools enforce charter constraints at interaction level

Failure modes:

- **charter drift** (rules change without visibility)
- **unenforced rights** (charter exists but does not constrain behavior)

5.3 Transparent surplus accounting

Revenue, fees, grants, and in-kind support are visible to members at useful granularity (DP6, DP17).

This MUST include:

- inflow sources and categories
- allocation breakdowns tied to functions
- linkage to ownership claims

Verification:

- members can trace value from source → allocation → outcome

Failure modes:

- **surplus opacity** (value cannot be traced)
- **extraction masking** (flows hidden behind aggregation)

5.4 Participatory budgeting and parameter control

Communities set budgets for safety, education (DP10), and incentives (DP9) through governed processes (DP12).

This MUST include:

- binding decision pathways
- budget execution tracking
- feedback loops into future allocations

Failure modes:

- **advisory budgeting** (decisions ignored)
- **capture of allocation power**

5.5 Credible exit and fork

Procedures to export collective artifacts, migrate identifiers where honest (DP5), and continue governance under divergent values without coercion.

This MUST include:

- executable export mechanisms
- continuity of identity, data, and governance artifacts

Failure modes:

- **exit suppression**
- **fork degradation** (loss of continuity)

5.6 Stewardship obligations

Ownership includes maintenance duties: moderation, security, inclusion, and accessibility commitments with accountability (DP1, DP15).

This MUST include:

- defined duties
- enforcement mechanisms
- reporting on fulfillment

Failure modes:

- **duty abandonment**
- **free-rider extraction**

5.7 Anti-capture controls

Rotation, conflict-of-interest rules, minority protections, and emergency pause pathways.

This MUST include:

- detection of concentration
- intervention pathways

Failure modes:

- **ownership capture**
- **governance lock-in**

5.8 Collective data governance

Shared corpuses require collective consent mechanisms and audit of downstream use (DP4).

This MUST include:

- consent pathways
- audit logs of use

Failure modes:

- **data extraction without consent**
- **loss of collective control**

5.9 Interoperable ownership artifacts

Membership and contribution receipts interoperate across tools (DP7).

This MUST include:

- portable formats
- degradation signaling across systems

Failure modes:

- **lock-in via incompatibility**

5.10 Succession and dissolution

Charters define succession for stewards and fair dissolution procedures.

This MUST include:

- transfer conditions
- fair distribution of residual value

Failure modes:

- **power vacuum**
- **unfair dissolution**

5.11 Intersectional inclusion in ownership

Governance design actively counters exclusion patterns through facilitation norms, translation, and accessible participation.

This MUST include:

- measurable inclusion practices
- correction mechanisms

Failure modes:

- **systemic exclusion**
- **ownership concentration through bias**

6. Governance, Accountability, and Agency Surfaces

DP20 requires that ownership is not only visible but **defensible and enforceable**.

Participants MUST be able to:

- verify ownership rights and mappings
- challenge illegitimate control or misallocation
- trigger governance review or dispute processes
- exercise exit and fork pathways without coercion

Communities MUST be able to:

- revoke or reassign ownership under defined conditions
- enforce stewardship obligations
- audit ownership actions and outcomes

Enforcement pathways include:

- rollback or invalidation of illegitimate actions
- governance-triggered reallocation of rights or surplus
- fork as a last-resort enforcement mechanism

Failure modes:

- **non-actionable ownership**
- **illegitimate control persistence**
- **ownership without recourse**

7. Incentives and Power Analysis

Ownership fails when incentives diverge from rights.

Key dynamics:

- **extraction loops:** value flows outward despite community contribution
- **token manipulation:** governance power decouples from responsibility
- **dependency capture:** infrastructure or distribution creates hidden control
- **soft capture:** influence accumulates without formal ownership

Adversarial patterns:

- governance capture through capital or coordination
- speculative ownership without stewardship
- platform rent extraction

Alignment requirements:

- ownership rights must correlate with value capture
- incentives must reward stewardship, not exploitation
- systems must detect divergence between formal ownership and real control

Failure modes:

- **symbolic ownership**
- **incentive inversion**
- **ownership erosion over time**

8. Community Signals Informing DP20

Across platforms and communities, recurring signals point to a shared breakdown between participation and ownership:

- maintainers and moderators demand compensation and decision power proportional to their labor
- skepticism toward “community-owned” claims following repeated governance failures and token collapses
- desire for portable community memory, identity, and governance tools
- frustration with value extraction from spaces built through collective effort
- growing interest in local, cooperative, and community-controlled digital environments

These signals are not isolated. They indicate structural gaps in how ownership is defined, enforced, and sustained.

DP20 treats these signals as design requirements, not feedback to be addressed after failure.

9. Foresight and Failure Design

DP20 assumes ownership systems will be tested by capture attempts, economic pressure, and governance failure.

Common failure paths include:

- concentration of ownership among early or privileged actors
- erosion of rights through informal overrides or hidden control layers
- suppression of exit or fork pathways to preserve centralized power
- divergence between formal ownership and actual value capture

DP20 requires designing safeguards in advance, including:

- transparent allocation and reallocation mechanisms
- enforceable limits on concentrated control
- clear and executable fork and exit procedures
- public postmortems linking failures to structural changes

Failure is expected. Illegible failure is not.

Foresight in DP20 also means anticipating success. Ownership structures fail differently when they grow: a small cooperative can govern by conversation, while a large one cannot. DP20 therefore expects communities to plan the transitions in advance rather than discover them under stress.

Scale transitions that require pre-designed responses:

- **From informal to formal.** Founding trust does not survive membership growth. Charters, rosters, and decision records must exist before informal authority becomes contested.
- **From volunteer to funded.** Introducing money into a volunteer commons reorders status. Compensation criteria and conflict-of-interest rules should be set before the first payment, not after the first grievance.
- **From single zone to federation.** Ownership artifacts that assumed one community must survive contact with many (DP7, DP8). Cross-zone recognition rules should be written while stakes are still low.
- **From founders to successors.** Every founding cohort eventually leaves. Succession, key rotation, and archive custody are ownership functions, not administrative details.
- **From growth to decline.** Communities shrink. Dissolution with dignity, including asset disposition and memory preservation, is part of ownership design (DP22).

Pre-mortem practice DP20 expects:

- name the three most likely capture vectors for this specific community, and the control that would detect each
- state in advance what evidence would indicate that ownership has become theater
- define the trigger conditions under which a fork is considered legitimate rather than hostile
- rehearse an exit at least once, so that portability claims are tested rather than asserted
- record what the community would refuse even if it were profitable, and where that refusal is written down

Failure design is not pessimism. It is the difference between a community that can survive its own mistakes and one that discovers its structure only when it breaks.

10. Knowledge Graph Stewardship

Communities do not only own spaces, funds, and governance artifacts. They also produce the semantic substrate that makes shared understanding possible: vocabularies, taxonomies, tags, annotations, curated links, corrections, glossaries, and the relationships that connect them. This substrate is a knowledge graph, whether or not it is called one.

Knowledge graphs are unusually vulnerable to quiet expropriation. They are built incrementally by many people, they carry no obvious authorship, and their value appears only in aggregate. A platform can absorb decades of community curation without any single act that looks like a taking.

DP20 therefore treats collective knowledge structures as ownable, governable, and forkable assets.

10.1 What is being stewarded

- **Vocabularies and ontologies:** the terms a community uses, their definitions, and their relationships
- **Classification schemes:** categories, tags, and topic hierarchies, including their edge cases and exclusions
- **Annotations and overlays:** notes, corrections, context, and interpretive layers attached to shared artifacts
- **Curation and linkage:** which sources are considered relevant, credible, or connected, and by whom
- **Provenance records:** who asserted what, when, and on what basis (DP15)
- **Glossary and translation layers:** cross-language term mappings and contested terminology (DP23)
- **Governance memory:** the record of how definitions changed and why (DP22)

10.2 Stewardship obligations

Ownership of a knowledge graph is custodial rather than proprietary. A community holding one accepts obligations:

- maintain provenance so that assertions can be traced to their source and revisited
- keep definitions versioned, so that meaning drift is visible rather than silent
- credit curation labor, including the unglamorous work of merging duplicates and fixing broken relationships
- resolve conflicting assertions through published process rather than by last-writer-wins
- preserve minority and contested interpretations instead of collapsing them into a single canonical entry
- publish the license and reuse terms under which the graph may be consumed
- retain the ability to correct or attenuate entries about people (DP4, DP18)

10.3 Rights the community must hold

- **Export rights.** The graph must be extractable in an open, documented form, including relationships and provenance, not only flattened content.
- **Fork rights.** A community that diverges must be able to take its semantic layer with it and continue evolving it independently (DP7).
- **Consent rights over derived use.** Bulk consumption for model training, resale, or downstream inference is a collective decision, not a default permission (DP4, DP11–DP13).
- **Attribution rights.** Systems that build on a community graph must disclose that dependency.

- **Refusal rights.** Communities may decline to encode knowledge that is sacred, protected, or dangerous to expose, and that refusal must be recordable rather than treated as a data gap.

10.4 Failure modes

- **Curation extraction:** a platform monetizes or trains on community-built structure while contributing nothing to its maintenance
- **Ontology capture:** a well-resourced actor gains effective control of definitions, shaping what the community can express
- **Schema lock-in:** the graph is technically exportable but semantically meaningless outside its original tooling
- **Silent redefinition:** terms change meaning without versioning, invalidating past assertions retroactively
- **Curation debt:** maintenance is unfunded, quality degrades, and the graph becomes unreliable while still being trusted
- **Consent bypass through derivation:** embeddings, summaries, or inferred relationships are treated as new works exempt from community terms

Example: A community maintains a topic taxonomy used by several tools. Its charter states that the taxonomy is exported monthly in an open format, that model training on it requires a governance vote, that three stewards are compensated for maintenance, and that a fork inherits full provenance history.

Why this matters: If communities own their spaces but not their semantics, someone else still decides how their knowledge can be described, found, and used.

11. Relationship to Other Desirable Properties

DP20 anchors ownership within the broader meta-layer system.

- DP3 defines how governance evolves under ownership
- DP4 constrains how collectively generated data can be used
- DP5–DP7 enable portability of identity, assets, and ownership artifacts
- DP6 and DP9 determine how value flows and incentives interact with ownership
- DP12 ensures ownership-linked governance can execute in practice
- DP15 ensures ownership claims and actions are provable
- DP17 ensures ownership structures can sustain themselves financially
- DP18–DP19 provide the participation and reputation inputs that mature into ownership

DP20 binds these properties into a coherent model of collective power.

DP20 also depends on the memory and language properties. DP22 preserves the governance lineage that makes ownership history legible over time, and DP23 ensures that ownership terms, charters, and votes remain accessible to members who do not share a dominant language. Ownership that cannot be read by its own members is ownership in name only.

12. Non-Goals and Explicit Boundaries

DP20 does not:

- require all systems to be collectively owned
- eliminate private enterprise or hybrid ownership models
- guarantee equal distribution of value or influence
- remove the need for legal structures and compliance

DP20 defines the conditions under which ownership claims are legitimate and enforceable. It does not prescribe a single model.

The following boundaries are stated explicitly, because "community ownership" is a phrase frequently used to describe its opposite.

DP20 does not mandate tokens. Tokenization is one instrument among many. Cooperatives, trusts, associations, stewardship councils, and non-transferable membership rights are equally admissible. A token that grants no decision rights is not ownership regardless of market depth.

DP20 does not require blockchains. Verifiable records may be maintained through several means. What matters is that ownership history is tamper-evident and independently checkable (DP15), not which ledger technology produces that property.

DP20 does not guarantee profit or surplus. Many commons will run at cost. DP20 requires that whatever surplus exists be visible and allocated under published rules, not that surplus be produced.

DP20 does not equate ownership with unanimity. Collective ownership includes the authority to decide over objection, bounded by minority protections and exit rights. Consensus is a method, not a requirement of legitimacy.

DP20 does not abolish operators. Communities may delegate operational authority to staff, vendors, or foundations. Delegation is legitimate when it is scoped, revocable, and recorded.

DP20 does not make forking costless. It requires that forking be possible with continuity of identity, memory, and economic position. It does not promise that forking will be painless or that both branches will thrive.

DP20 does not override rights of individuals. Collective ownership of a space does not confer collective ownership of its members' data, attention, or labor. Individual sovereignty under DP2 and DP4 constrains what a community may decide.

DP20 does not resolve legal form. Jurisdictional recognition of collective entities varies widely and will remain a constraint. DP20 requires honesty about the gap between digital rights bundles and legal enforceability rather than pretending the gap does not exist.

DP20 does not treat membership as property. Participation rights may be non-transferable by design. Preventing the sale of membership is compatible with, and often necessary for, durable community ownership.

13. Minimum DP20 Alignment (Non-Normative)

Minimum alignment defines the threshold where ownership is **real, enforceable, and not misleading**.

A DP20-aligned system **MUST**:

- bind ownership to executable governance and economic rights
- provide verifiable ownership records and history (DP15)
- ensure visibility into value flows and surplus allocation (DP17)
- enable credible exit and fork with continuity (DP4, DP7)
- maintain enforceable stewardship obligations

Failure modes to avoid:

- **ownership theater** (claims without control)
- **fork suppression** (no exit pathway)
- **surplus extraction without rights**
- **historical erasure of ownership changes**

Systems that omit execution, auditability, or exit **MUST NOT** be considered aligned.

The following statements describe what those conditions look like in practice. They are non-normative and are offered as an assessment aid rather than a conformance test.

13.1 Published rights bundle

There is a charter or equivalent document stating who the members are, what decisions they control, what share of surplus they hold, what audit rights exist, and how the charter itself may be amended.

13.2 Legible membership

Membership criteria, current membership, and the process for joining and leaving are visible to members. Informal power that operates outside the roster is identified rather than tolerated silently.

13.3 Binding decision surface

At least one class of consequential decision is actually decided by members, with a record showing the question, the participation, the outcome, and its execution (DP12).

13.4 Surplus and cost visibility

Members can see revenue, costs, reserves, and allocation for the current period, at a granularity sufficient to detect extraction (DP17).

13.5 Exercisable exit

Export of identity, memory, relationships, and ownership artifacts is documented, tested, and available without permission from an operator. Fork procedures are written before they are needed.

13.6 Anti-capture controls

There are published limits on concentrated control, including caps, quorum rules, rotation, or veto protections, and a record of when those controls were invoked.

13.7 Collective data authority

Uses of collectively generated data, including derived and aggregated forms, require a member-facing authorization pathway rather than a terms-of-service default (DP4).

13.8 Steward accountability

Delegated roles have scope, term, compensation, conflict-of-interest disclosure, and a removal procedure that members can initiate.

13.9 Continuity plan

Succession, key custody, archive stewardship, and dissolution terms exist in writing, so that the community can survive the departure of any individual.

14. Open Questions and Future Work

Key open questions include:

- how to design ownership models that function across jurisdictions
- how to balance tokenized and non-tokenized ownership structures
- how to maintain privacy while supporting interoperable ownership credentials (DP4)
- how to protect minority voices without blocking collective action
- how to measure contribution across visible and invisible labor (care, moderation, coordination)
- how to handle liability for collective decisions across legal systems

- how AI agents participate in ownership structures, if at all (DP11–DP13)

These questions reflect the boundary between social legitimacy and technical implementation.

Further questions raised by knowledge graph stewardship and scale transitions:

- what minimum schema should describe an ownership object so that it remains meaningful across zones and tools
- how should a fork inherit provenance, reputation, and knowledge graph history without importing the disputes that caused the split
- what licensing model best protects community-curated semantic layers from extraction while remaining genuinely open
- how should consent for model training on community knowledge be expressed, revoked, and verified downstream
- how should compensation for invisible maintenance labor be assessed without turning care work into a metric to be gamed (DP18)
- what governance form allows a community to refuse a lucrative offer without that refusal becoming a liability for its stewards
- how should dissolution allocate assets, archives, and namespaces when members disagree about legitimate succession (DP5, DP22)
- how can ownership rights remain intelligible to members across languages and literacy levels (DP23)

15. Path Toward ML-RFC

Advancing DP20 toward ML-RFC requires:

- standardizing ownership object and receipt formats
- developing reference implementations of community-owned systems with open accounting
- aligning ownership models with interoperability and identity standards
- testing fork and exit mechanisms in real communities
- integrating legal and cooperative expertise into design processes

Progress should be demonstrated through functioning systems, not only conceptual agreement.

16. Closing Orientation

DP20 is where the meta-layer turns participation into power.

It rejects the model where communities create value but do not control it.

When ownership is real, communities can govern, sustain, and evolve the systems they depend on.

When it is not, “community” remains a narrative layered over extraction.

Ownership is the difference between presence and permanence, between contribution and control.

DP20 is where the meta-layer stops confusing audience with citizenship.

Ownership is the difference between a group that is used and a group that endures, with memory, upside, and responsibility held together.

When DP20 is strong, people can build commons that last because the commons can belong to those who care for them.
